

Last-ditch attempt

On February 29, NVA forces made a final effort to storm Khe Sanh. The vaunted 304th Division—heroes of Dien Bien Phu and Lang Vei—launched a substantial ground attack along the eastern edge of the base. After heavy fighting, they were beaten back by the ARVN Rangers stationed there.

The siege and its incessant shelling continued through early April, when the US Army's First Cavalry Division kicked off Operation Pegasus to recapture Route 9 between the coast and Khe Sanh. To support the operation, Army and Marine engineers built a forward base with a landing strip just north of Ca Lu off Route 9, a feat achieved in just 11 days. Meeting relatively light resistance, First Cavalry Division were able to link up with Marines from the firebase on April 8, ending the 77-day siege.

US and ARVN forces together lost around 500 men during the siege; NVA figures were never known, although estimates range from 5,500 to 15,000.

Despite the siege being lifted, fighting continued around Khe Sanh as Marines and Army units tried to expand their zone of control and eliminate communist units remaining in the region. Going into the jungle in small patrols, the US forces incurred far higher casualties than during the siege itself.

As communist shelling of the base resumed, the US high command decided to abandon and destroy the combat base rather than risk another costly siege. The final troops were evacuated on July 5 and a few days later the North Vietnamese flag was raised over the ruined combat base.



Hide and seek

US soldiers set fire to Vietnamese huts between Khe Sanh and the coast during Operation Pegasus. After the bombing, Marines combed the area around Khe Sanh, flushing out any NVA troops hiding in the villages.